

Post-Quantum Cryptography

May 2026 · Renato Santi · zorthex.com

STATUS	LAG (L)	PEAK	CURRENT	MONTHS ABOVE
■ STRUCTURAL	91 mo	48/100	35/100	14

WHAT HAPPENED

From 2017 to 2024, Post-Quantum Cryptography existed in near-total public obscurity. The NIST final standard publication in August 2024 was the trigger — not a quantum attack, not a product launch. A regulatory act converted latent technical awareness into structural public attention in weeks. 91 months of lag closed in a matter of days.

This is the clearest documented case of regulation as an attention trigger in the Zorthex dataset. The pattern differs from Bitcoin (speculation), CRISPR (ethical controversy), and mRNA vaccines (health emergency). PQC attention was created by institutional mandate — and that changes everything about how it should be acted upon.

WHAT IT MEANS — THREE AUDIENCES

FOR INVESTORS & VENTURE CAPITAL

"Being too early is functionally identical to being wrong."

Investing in PQC startups between 2017 and 2023 meant burning capital ahead of market readiness — 91 months of near-zero public attention, no enterprise demand, no regulatory urgency. The structural window opened in August 2024. Enterprise adoption driven by compliance — not curiosity — is now underway. The Zorthex attention curve says: the market is ready. The lag is closed.

FOR CYBERSECURITY COMPANIES & CLOUD PROVIDERS

"Stop explaining. Start selling."

The educational marketing phase is over. 14 months above threshold confirm the public no longer needs to be told what PQC is — it needs solutions and migration paths. Budget should shift from awareness content to deployment tools. Current score: 35/100 — stable, institutional, compliance-driven. The attention curve says: the conversation has moved from 'what is this' to 'how do we implement this'.

FOR POLICY MAKERS & THINK TANKS

"91 months is how long a national security threat can exist before the public notices."

The Zorthex lag does not measure the threat — it measures the institutional delay. Post-Quantum Cryptography was a documented risk to national security from 2017. It took over 7 years for public attention to structurally consolidate. Zorthex quantifies this delay for any phenomenon — and gives policy makers a forward-looking signal before the pressure becomes unmanageable.

THE SIGNAL — MAY 2026

PQC attention is stable at 35/100 — above threshold, below peak. This is the absorption phase: organizations are responding to compliance frameworks, not novelty. The next trigger will be either a quantum computing milestone or a legislative mandate with hard deadlines. Watch for: enterprise migration announcements from major cloud providers, NIST implementation deadlines, and job posting frequency for PQC-related roles as a leading indicator.
